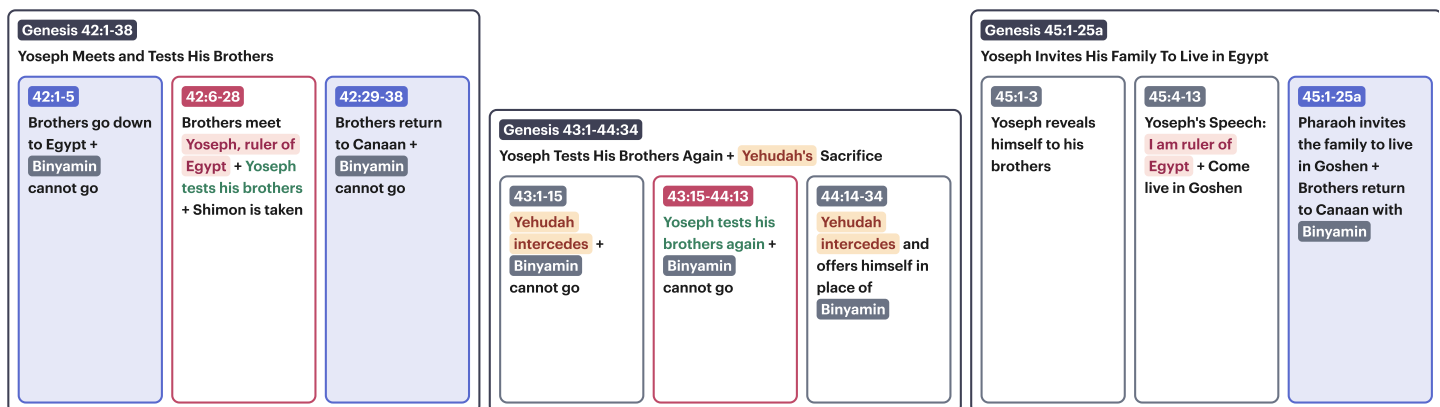


Session 13: The Brothers Go Down to Egypt

Key Takeaways

- Binyamin has replaced Yoseph in his father's heart as the beloved son.
- When Yoseph meets his brothers again, he turns their betrayal back on them, deceiving them and throwing them into prison. But ultimately, his aim is to test them.
- Yoseph accuses his brothers of coming to "look upon the nakedness" of the land (Gen. 42:9), identifying them with the sin of Ham when they ought to reflect the righteousness of Shem.
- The biblical authors put Yoseph testing his brothers on analogy with God testing Abraham.

Yoseph Tests His Brothers



Genesis 42:1-45:25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Act 2 of the story of Yoseph and his brothers consists of three main parts. The plot conflict between Yoseph and his brothers, which was set in the background for chapters 38-41 is now picked up and placed in the foreground again.

- In part 1 (Gen. 42:1-38), the conflict is introduced—Yoseph meets his brothers and tests their trustworthiness, imprisoning one.
- In part 2 (Gen. 43:1-44:34), the conflict intensifies to a climax—Yoseph tests his brothers again, compelling Yehudah to confess and offer himself as a substitute.
- In part 3 (Gen. 45:1-25a), the conflict resolves—Yoseph reveals himself to his brothers and invites his father and family to live in the safety of Goshen.

This forward, linear movement of parts 1-3 is simultaneously overlaid with a symmetrical literary design, indicated by the repetition of key words and themes.

42:1-5

- Ya'akov sends the brothers to Egypt for food: Binyamin cannot go
- **42:4** Ya'akov didn't send Binyamin, so that a disaster doesn't happen to him

42:6-28

- **42:6** Brothers meet Yoseph, ruler (השליט) of Egypt + Shim'on taken as a slave

42:29-38

- Brothers return to Canaan with food: Binyamin still cannot go
- **42:38** Binyamin not allowed to go, so that disaster doesn't happen to him

Genesis 43:1-44:34**43:1-15**

- Yehudah intercedes with Ya'akov, offering himself as a substitute for Binyamin

43:16-44:13

- Yoseph tests his brothers again + takes Binyamin as a slave

44:14-34

- Yehudah intercedes with Yoseph, offering himself as a substitute for Binyamin

Genesis 45:1-25a**45:1-3**

- Yoseph weeps and reveals himself to his brothers

45:4-13

- **45:8** Yoseph's speech: "Elohim has made me ruler (משל) of all Egypt"

45:14-25a

- Yoseph & brothers weep and he sends his brother back Ya'akov in Canaan with Binyamin

Genesis 42:1-45:25. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph's Brothers Are Sent to Egypt

Genesis 42:1-5

42:1

Ya'akov Sees That There Is Grain in Egypt

42:2

Ya'akov Orders His Sons To Go Down to Egypt for Grain

- "Buy grain, so that **we live and don't die!**" (מות + חיה)

42:3-5

Ya'akov Sends His Sons Without Binyamin

- 42:4 "So that a disaster doesn't happen (קרא) to him"
- 42:5 The sons go down to Egypt "Because the famine was severe in the land of Canaan"

Genesis 42:6-28

42:6-13

Yoseph Recognizes His Brothers, and Treats Them as Spies

- 42:10-11 "We came to buy grain ... we are upright, sons of **one (אחד) man** ... not spies!"

42:14-20

Yoseph Tests His Brothers and Demands They Bring Binyamin Down to Egypt

- 42:18 "Do this and **live (חיה)**"
- 42:20 "Let your words be proven trustworthy, **and y'all won't die (מות)**"

42:21-28

Yoseph Returns the Brothers' Silver and Sends Them Back to Canaan

- 42:27 "One (אחד) of the brothers opens his sack and finds silver"

Genesis 42:29-38

42:29-34

The Brothers Report to Ya'akov About the Harsh Ruler and the Loss of Shimon

- **42:29** The brothers return to the land of Canaan
- **42:29** They report to Ya'akov "all that happened (קרה) to them"
- **42:32** We said, "We are 12 sons of our father ... but one (אחד) is no more (איננו)"

42:35

The Brothers Find the Silver in Their Bags and Are Afraid

42:36-38

Ya'akov Responds to His Sons and Won't Allow Binyamin To Go

- **42:36** "Yoseph is no more (איננו), and Shimon is no more (איננו), and you would take Binyamin?!"
- **42:38** Binyamin's brother is dead (מות), so he will not go down with you ... so that a disaster doesn't happen (קרה) to him

Genesis 42:1-34. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yaaqov Sends His Sons to Egypt

¹ And Ya'akov saw that there was grain in Egypt,

and Ya'akov said to his sons,

"Why do you look at each other?"

² And he said,

"Look, I have heard that there is grain in Egypt,
go down there and buy grain for us from there,
so that we can live and not die!"

^a ³ And the ten brothers of Yoseph went down to buy grain in Egypt,

⁴ but Binyamin, the brother of Yoseph he did not send with his brothers,

^b because he said,

"So that disaster won't happen to him."

⁵ And the sons of Yisra'el came to buy grain in the midst of those coming,

ב'

^c because there was the **famine** in the land of Cana'an.

Genesis 42:1-5. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Going to Egypt for Food ... Again

Now that the famine has begun, Yaaqov sees that a life-and-death decision is before them: They must go to Egypt to get food. This invites the reader to recall the parallel moment in the story of Abraham, after he first entered into the land of Canaan in Genesis 12.

Genesis 12:10 Instructor's Translation

Now there was a famine in the land, and Avram went down to Egypt to sojourn there, because the famine was heavy in the land.

This story about Abram in Genesis 12:10-20 focuses on his lack of trust in Yahweh and how he lies about Sarai to preserve his own life at her expense. This Egypt-famine episode in Abram's life was set on analogy to the garden-fruit-tree episode in Genesis 3 and focused on Abram's deception. Abram took on the role of the deceptive snake lying about the beautiful tree as he lied about his beautiful wife.

In this story about Abraham's grandson (Yaaqov) and great-grandsons (the 12 sons) going to Egypt in a time of famine, we are again anticipating a story of deception. But this time, the deceiver and his motives are going to be totally different!

The New Beloved Son

Notice that Yoseph's brother Binyamin has taken the place of Yoseph as the beloved son of Yaaqov. In contrast to Yaaqov's careless sending of Yoseph to his brothers back in Genesis 37, here Yaaqov will not give up the final son of his beloved wife Rachel. Notice the contrast.

Genesis 37: Yoseph Sent to His Brothers

Gen. 37:12-13

And **his brothers** went to shepherd the flock of their father in Shkhem, and Yisrael said to Yoseph, "Aren't your brothers shepherding in Shkhem? Go, **let me send you to them** ..." And **he sent him** from the valley of Hebron, and he came to Shkhem.

Genesis 42: Binyamin Not Sent With His Brothers

Gen. 42:3-4

And **the brothers** of Yoseph, ten, they went down to buy grain in Egypt, but Binyamin, the brother of Yoseph **he did not send with his brothers**, because he said, "So that disaster won't happen to him."

Sending and Not Sending the Brothers. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Life and Death and Food

Notice how the themes and key words of Genesis 2-3 are being evoked and inverted here.

- Instead of abundant food in a garden, the land has become a food-desert in a famine.
- Instead of abundant life, the land will now lead people to death unless they strive to produce food through difficult work and suffering.

Yoseph Meets His Brothers

In this dramatic section, Yoseph has his first encounter with his brothers after 13 years. The scene unfolds in three steps.

A - Genesis 42:6-13: The brothers leave the land and meet Yoseph, who accuses them of being spies.

B - Genesis 42:14-20: Yoseph proposes a test to prove the character of the brothers; Shimon is imprisoned.

A' - Genesis 42:21-28: The brothers confess their sin against Yoseph and return to the land grieved and guilty.

⁶ Now, Yoseph was the ruler over the land,
he was the one **selling grain** to all the people of the land,
and **the brothers** came,
and **they bowed down to him**, faces on the ground,

⁷ and Yoseph **saw** **his brothers**,
a and he **recognized** them,
and he made himself **unrecognizable** to them,
and he spoke to them harsh things,
and he said to them,
b "From where have y'all come?"
And they said,
"From the land of Cana'an, **to buy food**."
a' ⁸ And Yoseph **recognized** **his brothers**,
but they did not **recognize** him.

⁹ And Yoseph remembered **the dreams which he dreamed about them**,

Yoseph Speaks

A **and he said to them**,
"Y'all are **spies**!
Y'all have come **to look upon the nakedness of the land**!"

Brothers Speak

¹⁰ **And they said to him**,
"No, my master!
Your servants have come **to buy food**."

11 We are **all sons of one** man.
We are **upright** !
Your servants are not **spies** !”

Yoseph Speaks

A' 12 **And he said to them** ,
“No! Y'all have come **to look upon the nakedness of the land** .”

Brothers Speak

B' 13 **And they said** ,
“Your servants, we are **two and ten brothers**
sons of one man in the land of Cana'an.
And look, **the little one** is with his father,
and the **one** , he is no more.”

Genesis 42:6-13. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Yoseph Inverts the Brothers' Schemes

Notice how this section consists of three parts, the outer frames focusing on Yoseph's encounter with his brothers (Gen. 42:6) and his dialogue with them (Gen. 42:9-13). These outer parts surround the center part, which focuses on Yoseph's recognition of them. This uncommon word “recognize” appears four times in a short space, and it forms a link back to the brothers' response to Yoseph's arrival back in Genesis 37.

Genesis 42:7-9: Yoseph Sees His Brothers

And Yoseph **saw** **his brothers** ,
and he **recognized** them,
and he made himself **unrecognizable** (וִיתַנְכַּר) to them.

And Yoseph **recognized** his brothers,
but they did not **recognize** him.
And Yoseph remembered the dreams which he dreamed
about them

“to make oneself unrecognizable” = Heb. **wayyitnakker**

Genesis 37:18-19: The Brothers See Yoseph

And **they saw** him from afar,
and before he came near to them,
they made a deceitful plan (וִיתַנְכַּל) to
kill him.
And they said, each to his brother,
“Look, this master of the dreams, he
comes!

“to make a deceitful plan” = Heb.

Joseph and His Brothers See Each Other. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Joseph and His Brothers See Each Other. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph's response to his brothers recalls the brothers' response to him back in chapter 37, which raises the question of Yoseph's motives. It would be understandable if he saw this as an opportunity for revenge against his brothers. But it's also possible that Yoseph's suffering has shaped him into a more self-aware person who will not flaunt his privileged position as he did when he was 17 years old.

A Test and the Nakedness of the Land?

When Yoseph accuses his brothers of being spies, he creates an opportunity to discover whether or not they will tell the truth. In other words, Yoseph is testing his brothers' integrity.

This explains why the narrative from this point onward contains numerous verbal hyperlinks back to the test of Adam and Eve's faithfulness in [Genesis 3](#).

Gen. 42:9

and he said to them, "Y'all are spies!

Y'all have come to **see the nakedness** of the land!"

Gen. 3:7

Then **the eyes of both of them were opened, and they knew that they were naked**; and they sewed fig leaves together and made themselves loin coverings.

Gen. 9:22

Ham, the father of Canaan, **saw the nakedness** of his father, and told his two brothers outside.

Genesis 3 and 9 in the Joseph Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

These two stories from Genesis 1-11 are themselves tightly connected.

- Because of the snake, Adam and Eve are deceived and eat the fruit that enables them to "see the nakedness" of their bodies and then provide somewhat pathetic clothing for themselves.
- Because of the wine of the garden, Noah becomes a drunk fool, and his son Ham (the ancestor of Egypt! See Gen. 10:6) sees his nakedness.

Here in [Genesis 42](#), Yoseph accuses his brothers of being like a foolish Adam and Eve coming up with inadequate responses to their nakedness and like Ham, father of Egypt, who takes advantage of others.

Dreams and Their Fulfillment

Notice also how this section draws attention to the dreams of Yoseph and how they are beginning to be fulfilled.

- Genesis 37: Yoseph dreams of becoming a ruler whose family bows down to him.
- Genesis 42: Yoseph remembers his dreams as his brothers bow down before him.

Yoseph ... The Disguised Deceiving Tester

The previous section portrayed Yoseph’s brothers as Adam and Eve figures who are looking for food and seeing nakedness. This section takes the analogies with Genesis 3 further—Yoseph will propose a test that will prove the trustworthiness of his brothers.

In an ironic twist, Yoseph becomes the disguised deceiver who accuses his brothers’ of treachery precisely in order to test their integrity. This is an inverted analogy, where Yoseph takes on the role of deceptive figures in Genesis, but with a different aim. His goal is not to trap his brothers but to recreate the scenario of Genesis 37 in order to see if they have changed.

- The spiritual being in Genesis 3 disguised as a snake ([Gen. 3](#)).
- Abraham lying to Pharaoh in Egypt ([Gen. 12](#)).
- Yaaqov disguised as his brother to deceive his father ([Gen. 27](#)).
- Tamar disguised as a prostitute to deceive her father-in-law in order to save the family ([Gen. 38](#)).

This last and most recent disguised deceiver is of special importance because the story of Yehudah and Tamar was placed right after the story of Yoseph and his brothers in order to create an analogy between the two.

The Third Day and the Loss of a Son

Notice that Yoseph’s proposal quickly changes from (a) all the brothers imprisoned and one goes back to Yaaqov to (b) only one of the brothers imprisoned and the rest go back to Yaaqov. Yoseph is being quick on his feet, trying to disorient the brothers, all in an effort to recreate the circumstances of their betrayal in [Genesis 37](#).

Genesis 42	Genesis 22
Yoseph tests his brothers “on the third day” to see if they will abandon one of their brothers.	God tests Abraham “on the third day” to see if he will surrender his beloved son.
Genesis 42	Genesis 37
Yoseph takes one brother and allows the others to abandon him in Egypt while they return with food.	Yoseph is the one brother taken, while the others abandon him to Egypt while they return with the bloody garment.
Genesis 42 Versus 22 and 37. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

How the brothers react in this “replay” of their betrayal will tell Yoseph everything he needs to know.

This story is also designed to link back to the binding of Isaac in [Genesis 22](#).

Reflection Question

How is Yoseph testing his brothers like God testing Abraham?